Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

Ruthie Foster

Ruthie Foster blends blues, Gospel and folk music, creating her own distinctive style. She is a prolific songwriter, and has garnered numerous awards for her contribution to American music. Her latest recording, on Blue Corn, is titled "Healing Time."

Ruthie was interviewed via Zoom on February 28, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive, and I'm very pleased to have Ruthie Foster with me. Thank you for your time and congratulations on your career.

RF: Well thank you. I'm happy to be here, I really am.

MR: I was, on the way up today, you know I've been actually looking forward to this for a few years now, and I was a tad nervous about getting things going and how to get the interview started. But I do believe in coincidences because I turned on in the car Sirius Radio and out came the Edwin Hawkins Singers singing "O Happy Day."

RF: Yeah. One of my favorites.

MR: Yes, so I felt better after that.

RF: Yeah. It'll do that. That song will do that.

MR: Did you have a choice early on about I'm going to go into music or I'm going to go into something else?

RF: I did want to, like every kid, want to be a veterinarian, you know you grow up with animals. And growing up in a small town around a lot of animals, and being a farm girl. I grew up on a family farm. So that was something that I knew would be first of all very needed, and then I get a chance to hang out with animals and not so many people. You know? It was just about that for me. Because I was a really shy kid. And in fact I had this stuttering, a little bit of a stutter issue growing up too because it just scared me to even hear my own voice sometimes. But yeah, that was one thing I thought about doing. But I knew I would definitely keep music, I wanted music somewhere in my life. I didn't know how that was going to happen but I was open to it.

MR: Did the church — vocalizing in the church choir help you get over that shyness?

RF: It absolutely did. And at the same time it scared me into hiding too. I would hide within the choir until I had a — there was this — we had what they call Youth Day where it was just all young people that would sing and give the messages and all of that. When everyone had to have a solo at some point. And it came time for me to have a solo ready one Sunday and that's when I realized okay, well this is something that's going to happen so let me just stand out front with a guitar, which was really unprecedented in this

particular area, a small town in the central part of Texas, a small church. Usually the piano is the first instrument. And it was my first instrument. But I wanted to play guitar and so I did my first solo on guitar, you know, when I got this opportunity to really just step up front.

MR: I'll bet you remember what the song was?

RF: I do. "Pass Me Not O Gentle Savior."

MR: If a singer, an adult in the choir played in a honky tonk on Saturday night playing the blues and pop music, were they welcome in the choir the next morning?

RF: Absolutely. At my church? Yes. Yeah. You know I remember moving back to Texas after being, living on both the east coast and the west coast, finally moving back in '93 and going back to my church as the piano player. Because they, at that point they had no piano player. So I said, "Well I'll try it, it's been a while since I've been pretty much the key piano player." So I became my church's piano player for about a year and I was s till playing clubs on Saturday night and I would, once in a while I'd come in a little bit late on Sunday morning and the ladies in the Amen corner had already started singing. And so I was doing my best to try to keep up with them. And I would do basically jump in and play along with them. And at the end of the service, this is what was extraordinary, they would always come up to me and go, "Baby we heard that you were at the cantina last night. Just wanted to know, was it a good crowd?" You know? It was total support. And I think a lot of it too was they knew that I was honoring my faith and I honored my background in Gospel music on the stage and I still do to this day. I mix Gospel with soul, with blues, with reggae in my sets. It's all a part of what I do and what my background is about. What I believe.

MR: It was a number of years ago when I saw you on Austin City Limits, not the most recent time but it was a small group. You had a woman who provided vocal harmonies and some percussion. And I was hooked from the get-go. It was late at night, I got home from a gig and I was just sort of winding down. And again, serendipity, I landed on this. And if I can recall the feeling it just seemed that even though the instrumentation was sparse that's all that was required at that time.

RF: Yeah. I think that has a lot to do with — keeping the instrumentation sparse was important for me. It had a lot to do with my wanting to keep the song up front. It's about the song for me, and I am a songwriter. I like to call myself a singer, but I love to think that I'm a songwriter first and that's important for instrumentation on stage. And yeah, I remember that night. I had a guitar player, drummer, bass player, and I think Cyd, Cyd Cassone was on percussion that night. Yeah, we kept it pretty simple. Pretty much the way my stage show was during that period.

MR: It seems that you have a fairly well defined vision for your music and I read this bit about you turning down a deal with Atlantic Records. Is that correct?

RF: I actually did take the deal and I was very careful with how I presented my songs. Because it was really a development deal. It wasn't necessarily a full on recording deal. And I had great counsel representation, lawyers, who helped me through that contract and understand that contract and be able to fulfill that contract, which was basically they wanted a specific amount of songs written within a specific amount of time and then your contract is over. And I fulfilled that. And so I was able to walk away knowing that I had fulfilled my duties in this contract. Not only that but I could walk away with my own songs.

MR: They hired you as a songwriter then?

RF: Basically hired me as a songwriter with, as a performer in development. In other words if they had chosen any of the songs I had written to record then that would lock me into basically not owning, first of all not owning those songs or the performance, or anything else. A lot of those contracts are really vague about owning the person, their name, their brand and I knew that. So I wrote songs, but I kept a few to myself too. And the songs that I did turn in, none of them really were contracted or basically picked to be recorded. So I recorded on my own.

MR: That little thing you just said reminded me of Nat Adderley, who was contracted to write a tune and he wrote "The Work Song" and he said, "Wait a minute, I'm going to keep this for myself and I'll write another one for you."

RF: Yeah. You know that's the trick. That was recommended to me by my representation and really just asking around. I asked a lot of questions when I lived in New York. I was a very curious songwriter. And I think that's how I ended up in certain circles and really learning a lot really quick while I was there. I was there for about three years and so I found myself in front of great songwriters like Julie Gold who wrote "From a Distance" and really picking their brains when it came to writing songs and the industry, how does that work and how does it work to your advantage. I took advantage of my time in New York to just really learn about the industry and meanwhile using the Atlantic name to get into a few big doors at the same time. So I got a chance to not work with but talk with Barry Eastman, who was the producer for Anita Baker. You know it was really important for me to just talk to people. I'm a conversationalist so for me it was about learning. And that's what I took a lot of those lessons that I learned during that period into my own songwriting and forming my own record label later. And my career now.

MR: Do you read through your lyrics when they're in progress as if they're a poem?

RF: Yeah. I do. I do. Melodically, melody is important to me. Groove is even, right up there with melody, but it's about the words, the lyrics and I started out writing poetry as a

young person. Some of my favorite poets were Dr. Maya Angelou and Gwendolyn Brooks, Nikki Giovanni, which I actually got a chance to talk to and see. These were some of my favorites, you know black poetresses. That was huge for me, growing up in the small town, being this little black girl in the middle of Texas. I wanted to read something that I could relate to, something that was written that said, basically told me — gave me an idea that someone else out there like me, and Maya Angelou was huge in my life during that period. *I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings* — that was huge. It blew the doors off of my feeling like I'm the only one out here who really loves the way of poetry and what poetry does for you, and how it moves you. And even in high school one of the ways I would actually make a little extra money, I wrote poems for my friends. Basically I had a lot of cousins. I had 22 cousins growing up. A lot of us lived all around each other. And you know my cousin Sherry — she had a new boyfriend, she wanted a new poem written about them so I'd just do that and then charge them a little bit of money for it. So that's how I started out, writing poems myself. So yeah reading lyrics, very much like poetry for me. It has a lot to do with the songs I pick too, to record.

MR: Did your tune "Small Town Blues" reflect that time years later?

RF: It did. "Small Town" had a lot to do with the town I grew up in, and it basically talks about that. Coming back to the small town after not being there for a while and realizing I had a hard time sleeping because it was so quiet. Because I had lived in cities after that. And so I talk about that in "Small Town Blues" yeah. And wanting to leave the small town and finding out after I left the small town I had a lot of reasons I needed to get back to that small town. And I did, eventually.

MR: I'd like to read — one of my favorites of yours, "Runaway Soul" — and it says, "I believe my soul has found a happy home/Left me here to suffer on my own." When I look at your song titles and your lyrics I see a lot of instances of this sort of push and pull between joy and pain, and that particular line has so much in it. Do you remember toiling over that line?

RF: I do. I remember that particular night just having a really rough night. I call it, when you get blue, I got blue. And it's funny people listen to that song and they think it's about being very up, but it really is what you caught on to, very push/pull. And it was one of those songs that just kind of wrote itself and I just remember having a hard time. I don't know if it was about a relationship, which is where I was in my life, but I just was having a really, really blue — not necessarily a dark night — but it was — I needed to just think about where I was and I felt like I was feeling — I felt very much alone but I know that there's somebody out there, there's something out there that's working its way to me. Meanwhile I'm going to do my best to just hold on and stay open and leave room for that, which is probably why it ended up being an uptempo blues song, really kind of a

push/pull. It's a shuffle but if you're really listening to the lyrics they say a lot more than your ordinary blues song. Thank you for catching that.

MR: Oh when you said, [sings] "Somebody help me" oh my God. There's nothing like a good shuffle in my opinion.

RF: Yeah. That's when I went Gospeling, you know started blues and just kind of — somebody help me. Woo. Yeah just reach out, reach out, somebody reach out. I'll reach out just grab my hand.

MR: I am so totally fascinated how the 12-bar blues has provided a template for thousands of songs of every topic, every groove. It's just the most elegant song form that I can ever think about.

RF: It's very true. I think that's why I tend to stay in and around blues. Because there's so much to experiment with it. And I do a lot of — I know I'm known as a blues singer and I do a lot of these, I do these cruises. And it gives me a chance to hear all different types of blues. And that keeps me going too. It gives me a lot of ideas. And a lot of my blues is mixed with other genres too. It's got a little bit of reggae in some of them, in some of the songs that I do I mix a little bit of that Bobby "Blue" Bland in the middle too. Yeah. It's very mixed. And you're right, blues says a lot.

MR: I saw the — the first time I saw a blues cruise advertised I had to chuckle because how can you possibly have the blues when you're on a cruise? But then I see you wrote "Singing the Blues" on a cruise, is that right? Staring at the mirror/Singing the blues.

RF: Yeah I wrote it on the legendary Rhythm & Blues Cruise, which I usually leave from once a year. I take my entire band. I started out duo and I think we're up to sextet now and we're probably going to be nine of us on stage by the end of this year, it just gets bigger. I did, I wrote "Singing the Blues" after I went to see Bobby "Blue" Bland play. And each of these bands, I think there's like twenty bands or so on these cruises and they play, each band plays maybe twice, maybe three, four times sometimes. And I think I saw all of Bobby "Blue" Bland's performances. I did not want to miss it. And I had just such a great time hearing him sing and standing right in front of him with his band playing, he's got the Captain's hat on and I had just finished this song — or I thought I had just finished this song, but I remember watching him and thinking I have to get back to my cabin. I have more to say and I want to put his name in this song, and that's how he ended up in "Singing the Blues." And I think "Singing the Blues" has that — it's not a shuffle but it has that boat rock if you will — not rock the genre but it has that sway to it where I got that idea from listening to Bobby "Blue" Bland and his horns, because he had a horn section that would basically give you that groove. It was about the groove.

MR: You went to music school. I'm trying to form a question here about being what we call a schooled musician versus say self-taught musician. Have you noticed that self-taught

musicians may come up with things that schooled musicians might not — it might not occur to them?

RF: That's true. Yeah. I consider myself both. I was self taught when it came to guitar. I taught myself how to play guitar. But when I did go to school, to music school, I did learn the proper way to tune a guitar. I used to tune to an open G and I learned the proper way to tune a guitar when I went in to study music. And as a singer I went into my vocal major as a Gospel singer. I had grown up singing, so very much self taught in that way. But here I was learning how to not just read music, which I could read music, I had piano lessons from sixth grade on. But this was learning how to arrange and compose for a big band, rock bands, country bands, improv jazz bands. That was a totally different animal for me so I had to, I had this learning, this music degree which I do have, and then I have this upbringing where I taught myself and watching other singers and other musicians. So I kind of came from both worlds. And you're right, a lot of the guys and gals that I went to school with, they would come with their own arsenal of what they knew too, and I do recall being able to pull myself away from the page from reading as a self taught singer, and find my own interpretation of a song. And I think it was pretty universal with a lot of these kids that I was in school with. A lot of really talented folks came out of the school too, yeah.

MR: When you were spending that year as a Gospel pianist, did you — how did you figure out how to play Gospel piano?

RF: I'm still figuring out how to play Gospel piano.

MR: Because sometimes I hear them, I mean I play the piano but sometimes I hear some of the better Gospel pianists and I go, "Oh what is that? I need to know what that is."

RF: Yeah. It's really different, right? It's more about groove than anything, and feeling and wow, interpreting the room. It's about reading the room too as a piano player in a Gospel church. Because the room changes. There's a lot of energy happening that can be way up here, where it's just over the top, where there's so much spirit flowing in the church. And you're pounding as hard as you can to be heard too, because the sound system is usually terrible at a lot of these old churches. And then there's this period of when it comes down to, it's just nothing but humming and someone's praying in the corner, and then you're trying to find your way as a piano player to interpret that energy as well. And then there's a whole 'nother thing that happens when the collection plate goes around. You want to inspire people to drop a little something in the collection plate so you kind of give it a little — you try to find the energy for that too. Yeah, you're working, as a Gospel piano player, all the time.

MR: Yeah on occasion I've played "Pennies from Heaven" when they pass the collection plate. But they need more than pennies, that's for sure.

RF: Yeah that's brilliant though, I like that.

MR: Talking about that spirit that occurs, I was watching the recent Crescent City Blues performance of yours and your band. You played a song by Sister Rosetta Tharpe. And it was happening. And at the end you were going "Woo" and you said, "I had to grab my knees on that one. Something swooped down and caught me." So if I have a question here it's can you describe what that feels like? And can you make it happen?

RF: Oh. Can I describe what that feels like? Mmm. To me it feels like it's just spirit you know. Because sometimes I mean we do these songs every weekend, sometimes three, four times a week. And there's that something that happens on that third night or that fourth night and you're doing the song and it just feels different. Everybody is in the pocket. Everyone on the stage that's playing the song with me, which is in the pocket. We're feeling it. And I think it has a lot to do with everybody going through their own thing. You know I have a bass player, I have a piano player, drummer, and sometimes guitarist. And sometimes I'm playing guitar and it's a lot of work for me to try to — I'm singing and playing guitar and trying to be a decent rhythm player. And it's a lot of work. And sometimes, you know the song is all I have to lean into and lean on. And I find myself really digging into the song vocally, energy-wise, and I've got people in front of me sometimes that are really into it. And that particular day, the Crescent City Blues Festival, these people were jazzed and they were just, you could feel it. And you see it when people just decide to just stand up. And that takes me back to church because that's what you do in church, you stand up when you just feel it. And you just want to witness it. You want to get closer to that energy. And you've got people that are walking down front, they're leaving their chairs. That's what was happening that day. There's something about "Up Above My Head" is the Sister Rosetta Tharpe song that felt really on point that night. And that's why, yeah, after the song I was wiped, after one song. And it just made me feel like okay. And it just felt like I just did a one-on-one basketball game with somebody. I needed to grab my knees and rest for a bit. Yeah. I don't know any other way to describe that feeling but I do remember it just touched me. Yeah.

MR: The jazz singer Sheila Jordan talked about very rare occurrences where she left her body and she was as if she was watching herself sing.

RF: It's very much that. I've sat with my friends and shared that too, that I do feel more of just a conduit, and I'm just there to remind you that the energy is here. It's everywhere, and I'm letting it go through me so that I can give it to you, so that you can give it back and it comes through me again, and you just start feeling that. That's what's building as the night rolls on. Yeah. And that's a lot to do with why I talk. I give a little bit of a background for a song but a lot of times it's about giving myself time to come back down and prepare for the next song. It's very vibration oriented.

MR: Vibration. I like that.

RF: Yeah. Vibration. Yeah. Huge.

MR: Did that mic talk come natural to you? I know you said that you were shy and sort of hiding in the Gospel choir, but you obviously got over that because you do engage the audience with your music but also in between.

RF: Yeah. You know I think a lot of that came, it did not come natural at first, naturally. It was something that I had to learn and what I was learning was how to be comfortable in my own body. How to be comfortable with myself and share my own stories. It came from that. And honestly living — just talking about my own life and talking about how I grew up, just giving people a piece of myself and talking about my grandmother, and talking about my mother and my cousins and my pa-pa driving — what it was like living in Six Mile on the river. A lot of it came from my own real stories and being really comfortable with that kind of brought it together for me so that in between banter is kind of part of my shows. In fact you know just before this interview I was just trying to — I'm trying to rehearse for a couple of shows that are coming up and I don't have my guitar player with me and so I'm going to have to learn a lot of the guitar parts so I'm listening to the recorded — a recorded concert, trying to learn the guitar parts. But there's so much talking in between each song that I did, I'm having to fast forward, fast forward, where is the song? Yeah. I find myself talking quite a bit. Some of it is nervous energy and some of it is just really me just trying to find — what the nervous energy is about me trying to find my ground on where the audience is. It's a way of reading the audience for me. And I get a chance to crack a joke and I see who's ready to have some fun through that you know. I have a few standard things that I say but for the most part I'm just feeling my way around the audience to see, what do we have here. Because each one is different. Every show is completely different.

MR: Did your parents or grandparents and cousins — have they had a chance to see you in your concerts?

RF: Yeah a few have. Yeah. Down through the years I've had several of my cousins show up and they love it when I talk about our grandparents — Big Mama and Pa-Pa and growing up on the river. And once in a while I'll mention their name — they get a kick out of that. And I feel like it's a way to keep our kin folks alive, you know our kin folks very much in the music and for me it's huge because it gives me a chance to, first of all, I get to bring them with me. I get to bring my Big Mama and my Pa-pa with me, and my mother, on stage with me. And then that goes back to your other question about I can open up and just let them sing through me. That's really what you're hearing on a lot of these concerts. They're not concerts for me anymore. These are, you can call them concerts, but this has given me a chance, when I'm on stage I try to be true to myself and true to

the song, true to the energy in the room, and just be one with that. I could — it doesn't even have anything to do with singing in English, which I've proven — many of us in the music industry when we sing anywhere where people don't even speak English, it's just something about making contact with what's going on in the room, and that's everything.

MR: Oh, that's wonderful. Did I read you have a daughter?

RF: I do.

MR: And what does she think about your career? Did she learn what the word "gig" meant early on?

RF: Oh yeah. She knows what that means and I ask her all the time, so what do you think you might want to do when you grow up, with your life. She's eleven right now, soon to be twelve in a couple of months. And you know she names school teacher, and a couple of other things, and then she puts singer — would be the last thing, if those don't work out. So I'm fine with it being the last thing. I just want to make sure that that is, you know, that she's prepared for that too. But yeah, she sings.

MR: Excellent. As a headliner and an artist, I'm going to surmise that you have a certain amount of pressure on you to keep working, you have a family and you have side musicians that you want to provide gigs for. Over the years have you ever had to be in a situation where a producer or people pulling the strings wanted you to change your approach because they thought it would be more financially rewarding?

RF: Um hum. That's happened. Yeah. That happened early on in my career. And not so much now. Once in a while, I've had a producer to try that on. But that was a very short conversation you know without even getting — I didn't even have to get angry about it or even concerned. I just stated where I was and where I was staying. And it was the end of that. And we went on about recording the way I wanted to hear this particular song. Yeah once in a while I'll run into that.

MR: Do you record — this may change from one CD to the next — but do you mostly record live with your band?

RF: Yeah, you know actually I don't — this last CD that I did, "Healing Time" is recorded with my band and we did record live for the most part. Yeah. Come to think of it, as far as the rhythm section yeah, we definitely did play live for "Healing Time." And looking back I played live for the most part on most of my recordings, but not all. And I used studio musicians up until now and the last CD, "Healing Time," is actually my band for the most part and I had a group of guys that, a wonderful group of guys in New Orleans that were produced by Mark Howard. We played live in the same room, honestly. There were no, you know, in the control booth. And that was fun. Yeah.

MR: Yeah I listened to "Healing Time" and there's a phrase not so much anymore but, "Wow that jumps off the record." And that tune jumps off the record.

RF: "Healing Time?"

MR: Yeah.

RF: Yeah.

MR: It's like, and it sounds like there was more arranging to be done with some horn parts and a choir and so forth. Was there a discussion about this next CD is going to sound somewhat different from what came before it?

RF: I think it was unconsciously done that way. We — I did want to write with my band on this one. This was the first album we've actually written together and that was huge for me because I had — we had just come out of the pandemic, just that January, out of the pandemic and started recording. And not even just recording but writing. We were recording and writing about the same time as much as we could. And I wanted to honor, I really wanted to honor my drummer and friend Samantha Banks. She passed away in '19, in 2019 of a stroke and that really, it took a lot out of all of us. And I wanted to honor her memory and her musicianship by bringing the band in for this next project and record and perform and write as a family, as my band family. And I've got to say it just kind of happened. I think the reason this record, and I'm proud of all of my albums, but this one really is special to me mostly because I'm close to it and you know it's just out, but because my band is on there and there's so much love and respect and sweat and hours of recording and re-recording and sequencing the songs so that they sound great together coming in and out of each other. And then working on the songs so that we can perform them live especially after all of the arranging that you noticed has to be — all of that was added after we did the basic, the base part. That's huge for me. A lot went into this album and a lot of my own money went into this own album. So yeah I'm really close to this one. And I know they're real proud of it too. I've watched and I read interviews that they're doing about their own songs. All of my band members have their own careers and play with other bands and their own bands. So they know what goes into making a record from writing, from concept to playing it on stage. And that's why I really respect them all for that. They know how much work goes into that. And because of that we're all real proud of this album, "Healing Time."

MR: How many people are usually in on the mixing?

RF: Yeah. The basic tracks usually involve all of the band, everybody's there. We may not all play at the same time, it depends on the studio and how it's set up. And then we might go back in and add percussion, add another keyboard part, background, vocals, and then we have a mixing, an opportunity to actually sit and mix. And that usually involves me and the producer and maybe a couple of band members who want to be a part of that. It's very time consuming, the mixing part. And then we send it off to be mastered, and that's a whole 'nother process where, you know, that thing what you say where a song leaps off

the, it leaps out at you — a lot of that is in a really good mix, but also really the mastering too is what makes that happen. And we went through a couple of different versions of mixes with this album too. And it took a while because of the mixes. We wanted to — we had a mix sent back to us — for me it may have been too much bass on this particular song, can you pull that back, send it back to mixing, get it back, okay the guitar part is a little — it's kind of overpowering the vocals on this track, can we bring that part down. Another track we — I think we have eight different mixes of because we just couldn't find the right tempo. We kept slowing it down and speeding it up, and I think that was "Lie Your Way to the Truth." That one started out really, really slow and then we realized, put it in context with the rest of the album, it needed to be a little quicker. So that's — we've got about, we have really special names that we made up for the versions too. This is the quick time version, you know, this is the slow poke version.

MR: I can just imagine you know, after listening to a mix like 60 times you're going I just don't know what to say anymore.

RF: Yeah. That was usually me. My ears just get tired and I have to just throw it to my manager, or give it back to the producer. You guys, you're going to have to decide, I can't. I don't hear a difference anymore. Yeah. It happens.

MR: Did you ever have a producer when you're in the early stages of recording, getting ready to record, that didn't quite agree with you on what original material to include on a record?

RF: All the time, yeah. That's all the time. There's no animosity involved, it's just kind of a "yeah, no." That's it. And you know, and I trust my producers. I've worked with several over the years and I trust and respect them all. And then sometimes it comes to, "No, I want that one. That one stays, that one stays." Yeah.

MR: What would a member of your band, this is kind of an odd question but I like aspiring musicians to be aware of the work ethic. What would a musician in your band do to make you aggravated to the point of okay I need a new X player.

RF: Well I can tell you right now with me it's showing up on time when you're recording. Because that's money. And if the money — what, they had a saying in the Atlantic when I was at Atlantic — time is money and the money is mine. So showing up on time is a big one. And that's just being professional, that's just — if you're going to call yourself a professional show — at least respect the person you're working with or working for, by showing up on time, even a little early is fine. Knowing the material is huge, and that's a no-brainer. Being flexible on, maybe playing a song a different way. Taking constructive criticism is really important too, because I've seen people early in my career — not only on the records I've recorded but my early recording days I've seen guys and ladies just shut down and it's easy to do when you feel like you've been sitting there for hours and

you're trying to give this producer what he wants but you're just not giving him what he wants and you, but you keep playing the same part over and over, you're not changing anything about it. In a lot of ways that's just basically saying you've turned off. You've shut down. So it's okay to ask for breaks if you really need one, even if you just need to go scream. You know? It's okay to do that. You know because that's taking care of yourself as a player. You want to show up with your best self. That's important. God there's so many. That's a great question though for someone who needs to know this stuff going in.

MR: Have you ever had someone who had so much technique but they couldn't rein it in to be in an accompaniment role?

RF: Um hum. Yeah. That's related to all of the things you should know going into the studio, definitely related to that, where you're basically overthinking. A lot of some great recordings have been done where it was just a first take you know. The guys and gals got in there and they sat down, they're relaxed, had a little something to eat. But you know I'll get back to that, the having something to eat, because that'll shut you down quick too. I know people who will just stop and take a nap and then they're done for the day. You can't even get them back up. But yeah I think it's about relaxing, yeah, and sometimes that first take — just be ready when the — back in the day when they had a light to let you know when you're recording. When that light goes on just be ready. Be prepared. Know your skill.

MR: I liked a moment that happened on — I think it was the tune "I Really Love You" from the "Truth According to Ruthie Foster." Wayne Jackson and this little muted trumpet thing. It just sounded so spontaneous.

RF: Yeah. I think it was. We didn't expect him to pick up the mute for his trumpet. Because he didn't rehearse it that way when we were going over the song. And Wayne was one of those people where he showed up, and I didn't realize this: these guys, the Memphis Horns is what you're talking about, Wayne Jackson and the Memphis Horns, they didn't show up with music at all. And I thought that was really odd coming from a girl who — you know I went to school for music and that's what horn players do usually when they show up to a studio. And Wayne just wanted to hear the song, he wanted to have us just play it through a few times. And he said, "Um hum" and he had his horn with him right there in the control room and he's playing a few parts. And I see him, he's talking to the guys. And I think he was just telling them what — "You're going to do the third here, you do the fifth and then we'll scoot down to the" blah-blah-blah. And it went on. And we played it through a couple of more times and he went into the studio and the part came up. And I saw him pick up the mute for the horn and I'm thinking okay what's he doing, this is different. And that's what came out, what you're hearing on that particular

song. And it's perfect, absolutely perfect how that turned out. Genius. Loved working with Wayne.

MR: Wow. That's a great story.

RF: There are a lot of great stories from that session by the way.

MR: There's a — jeez didn't you have Robben Ford on — was it that record or I don't know there's some heavy duty guitar on that.

RF: Yeah. That's Robben Ford. We caught Robben. Robben is at the time, and he may still be, was semi-retired. And I know what that means in the music world, it just means you show him enough money and they've got time, and they love you like I hope Robben still does, they'll come by, they'll swing by. And that's what he was doing. He was swinging by on his way to Memphis because he was on his way to Italy. He was spending time in Italy at the time. And I made it affordable for myself by putting myself in one of the low budget hotels and I took care of them, my guys, to make sure they had what they needed. I rented this big Lincoln, because that's what you do in Memphis, right? I rented this beautiful car and I was their chauffeur, I went and picked them up from the hotel. We stopped at Starbucks and I got to know what their orders are, I order their favorite drinks. We scoot over to Ardent Studios where Isaac Hayes — all these wonderful people have recorded down through the years. Make sure they've got their snacks, barbeque, something for the vegans, something for the vegetarians. I took care of my fellas.

MR: I want to work for you. You just gave me a flash. I did a bit of session work one time in Ardent Studios and the guy there goes — he points to a B3. And he said, "That's the organ Booker T played "Green Onions" on. I said, "Whoa."

RF: Yeah. There's some serious history in that place, just scary. Yeah. I spent most of my time just looking at the walls. They have wonderful pictures of the sessions that were going on in that place on the walls. So yeah. It was one of those things where, again, energy — you just walk around feeling the walls. Get me some of that. You know? Wow. What a place.

MR: I hope you're up on the wall as well.

RF: Oh that would be sweet. Yeah.

MR: Can your music be spiritual but not necessarily religious?

RF: Um hum. That's exactly what I feel that my music is and that's where I feel comfortable where it is about spirit, very spiritual. And not necessarily about any particular religion. I know a lot of people do take my songs and they've been recorded in churches and sung still in church choirs and college choirs and I think that's great. You know it's more spirit. In fact my drummer, you might see there's a picture, that's me and her back there. It's Samantha. She used to call it "spirit music" when people asked, "What type of music do you guys do?" And she says, "It's spirit music." Music that moves your spirit. And the

other thing she used to say when I would go out and do my own shows by myself, solo shows, and she would call and remind me, "You've got this girl, just go and make 'em cry."

MR: Aw. That's lovely. A couple more things and I'll wrap up, this has just been marvelous. I wanted to run a couple of names by you and just see how they — what they might elicit. Mahalia Jackson?

RF: Powerful. Nothing but power. Absolutely. I grew up listening to a lot of Mahalia, and still do. Still do. To remind myself when you sing remember where that comes from and not just spirit-wise but even physically. You're listening to her sing and she's a very physical singer. As a vocalist or just as a musician who's knowledgeable about that and the physics of when it comes to how you use your body, you see and you feel that with Mahalia. You know where it's coming from.

MR: How about Joe Williams, not Big Joe Williams, Joe Williams of the Basie —

RF: Yeah. Yeah. What I love about Joe Williams is his phrasing and really relaxed way of singing, his style. Yeah. Very, very stylish and he picked some really great tunes as well.

MR: I noticed a similarity between you and him, and it might sound a little odd but in the Crescent City video they had some close-ups of you and the way you were using your mouth and your vocal cavity, sticking out your chin, I mean the whole thing. And Joe performed here a number of times and I got to see that, and he did that as well, almost as if he was a trained opera singer.

RF: Oh I got that from him too. Yeah he had a way of moving into his vocal — moving around his vocal range. I've never seen — you know I didn't watch enough of his video to see that. Now I'm going to have to go back and really catch that. For me, I am trained, I am a trained vocalist. I had one of the best coloratura soprano instructors/teachers at my music school, Lorna MacDonald who I think she's the head of the vocal department, music department in University of Toronto right now. Yeah. She worked with me on range. And a lot of that is very much, is physical, in what you do with your body, what you do with your mouth, how you move air through your throat, how to even hold a note. Because I have certain songs where I'll hold notes for long periods of time. It's just technique, the technique that I was taught. So yeah. I'll have to check those out, Joe Williams, so I can see that.

MR: Yeah. "Every Day I Have the Blues."

RF: Yeah. "Every Day." Uh huh.

MR: What do you do to keep yourself healthy?

RF: Ooh. I try to get sleep though that's not always successful when you're on three-week tours which is what I'm looking at right now. You just drop when you can. I try to eat well, that's been more and more important, the more — I won't say older, but the wiser I

get. As Maya Angelou says when you know better do better. So I try to do better by nutrition. In fact I went ahead and — I went got a Nutrition and Fitness Certificate, certification, just so I can educate myself on vitamins and supplements and different types of foods and how your body works with that. And that was really important for me. Plus I love to learn. I read a lot. So I messed around I got myself certified. That was pretty wild. Didn't expect to even pass that test but I guess I test well too, the wiser I get.

MR: Mind and body.

RF: Yeah it's huge. Mind and body, soul. Mind, body and spirit. You want to keep all of that working together. That's important, especially for a singer and these days any or everything is floating around.

MR: Speaking of that if you watch the morning news daily do you wonder about the state of human nature in the last five or six, seven years?

RF: I do. Especially having a child in this world too. Yeah I do. And I try to remember what my place is through music and what I can do to do my part in keeping — if anything, keeping spirits up, keeping spirits on the up. That's important for me. Yeah. It's been interesting watching this as a humankind and how we're treating each other. But I think it was Pete Seeger that really opened my eyes to, it was Pete and Odetta — I had a chance to sit with both of them at different times — that reminded me that we have — our work is in our music. And they reminded me that what we do and what we say really matters, and what we sing even more and that music can change hearts, music can change minds, music can change lives, and always remember that. And I try to remember that when I record too. I try to be very mindful of what I'm putting down, what I'm recording. It's very important to me to put my messages — not necessarily be positive all of them, because I want people to know that I'm a human being. I've been up and I've had some serious trials, still do. And they'll keep coming. But my music is my way of working through that and hopefully people can use my music for that too, in their own trials and triumphs.

MR: That's an excellent coda to our session here. Well this has just been a joy for me, thank you for the joy in the morning as you said, and the afternoon and evening.

RF: I love that.

MR: Yeah. And I wish you continued success, and thank you for the good shuffles.

RF: You're welcome. Thank you for the good questions.

MR: You're welcome.

RF: Those are great questions.

MR: And I hope the tour goes well, and "Healing Time" as well.

RF: Oh I appreciate that. Thank you.

MR: I'll sign us off and we'll say our good-byes.

556 RF: Okay.